

Customer Journey & Onboarding Experience Analysis of Notion

A Customer Success Case Study

1. About the product



Customer Journey & Onboarding Experience Analysis — Notion

This case study evaluates the end-to-end onboarding journey to identify friction points, user experience gaps, and opportunities to improve activation, feature adoption, and long-term engagement.

2. Project Objective

Objective

The objective of this project is to analyze the onboarding journey of a first-time Notion user from a Customer Success perspective, identify friction points that impact activation and feature adoption, and recommend practical, business-focused improvements to enhance the overall customer experience.

The analysis evaluates how effectively Notion guides new users from account creation to their first meaningful interaction with the product. By combining Customer Journey Mapping, UX evaluation, and Customer Success principles, this case study aims to uncover opportunities to improve onboarding clarity, user confidence, and long-term product engagement.

Scope

This project evaluates the customer journey across the following onboarding stages:

- Landing Page & Product Discovery
- Account Sign-up
- Email Verification
- Workspace Creation
- User Personalization
- AI Workspace Generation
- Desktop App Recommendation
- Sidebar Navigation & Feature Discovery

Deliverables

- Customer Persona
- Customer Journey Map
- Journey Observations
- Key Insights
- Customer Pain Point Analysis
- Prioritized Improvement Opportunities
- Expected Business Outcomes

- Final Customer Success Case Study
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Success Criteria

User Success Criteria

A successful onboarding experience should enable a new user to:

- Understand Notion's value proposition quickly.
 - Complete workspace setup with minimal friction.
 - Reach their first meaningful product experience efficiently.
 - Discover core features with confidence.
 - Feel encouraged to continue exploring the platform.
 - Build confidence in using Notion independently.
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Business Success Metrics

An effective onboarding experience should contribute to:

- Faster user activation
 - Higher feature adoption
 - Reduced onboarding friction
 - Improved customer satisfaction
 - Increased user engagement
 - Stronger long-term retention
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3. Customer Persona

Persona Name

Alex Johnson

Age

24

Occupation

Early-Career Professional

Industry

Knowledge Worker / SaaS User

Technical Proficiency

Intermediate

Comfortable using digital tools and productivity software but new to comprehensive workspace platforms like Notion.

Goals

- Organize personal and professional work in one workspace.
- Improve productivity through structured workflows.
- Collaborate effectively with teammates.
- Explore AI-powered productivity features.
- Build an efficient knowledge management system.

Motivations

- Stay organized.
- Save time on daily tasks.
- Increase productivity.
- Learn modern digital tools.
- Simplify work management.

Pain Points

- Unsure where to begin after signing up.
- Overwhelmed by multiple onboarding choices.
- Difficulty discovering high-value features.
- Needs clear guidance during initial setup.

Expected Outcome

"I want a simple onboarding experience that helps me understand Notion quickly so I can confidently organize my work and become productive from day one."

4. Customer Journey Map

Stage	Customer Goal	Customer Emotion	Experience Summary	Customer Success Evaluation	Key Opportunity	Journey Rating
Landing Page	Understand what Notion offers and create an account.	😊 Curious	The landing page communicates Notion's value proposition clearly with a clean design. However, the CTA wording and login flow create slight uncertainty for first-time users.	Strong first impression with minor clarity issues.	Improve CTA clarity and differentiate the login experience for existing users.	★★★★☆
Sign-up	Create an account quickly.	😊 Confident	Google sign-up provides a fast and frictionless registration experience requiring minimal effort.	Excellent onboarding efficiency with almost no friction.	Set expectations by showing the remaining onboarding steps.	★★★★★
Email Verification	Verify account and continue onboarding.	😊 Neutral	The verification process is straightforward and easy to complete, although a success	Smooth but could improve user confidence	Display a confirmation message before	★★★★☆

Stage	Customer Goal	Customer Emotion	Experience Summary	Customer Success Evaluation	Key Opportunity	Journey Rating
			confirmation before continuing would improve reassurance.	through better communication.	redirecting users to onboarding.	
Workspace Creation	Start using Notion immediately.	😞 Confused	A large number of workspace invitations shifts attention away from the primary goal of creating a personal workspace, increasing cognitive load for new users.	High-impact onboarding friction that delays activation.	Prioritize workspace creation for new users while keeping invitations easily accessible.	★★☆☆☆
Personalization	Customize the workspace according to personal needs.	😊 Interested	The onboarding questions are simple and relevant. However, the AI participation option is easy to overlook due to its placement and wording.	Good personalization with missed opportunity to improve AI adoption.	Increase visibility of AI features through stronger messaging and visual emphasis.	★★★★☆
Desktop App Recommendation	Decide whether to install the desktop application.	😞 Thoughtful	The page clearly communicates the benefits of the desktop application while allowing users to skip installation. Permission requests could be explained more transparently.	Builds value effectively but could strengthen user trust.	Improve transparency around permission requests before installation.	★★★★☆
AI Workspace Generation	Build the first workspace.	😄 Amazed	Notion AI can generate a complete workspace from a simple prompt, creating a strong "Aha!" moment. However, this capability is not communicated clearly enough before users interact with it.	Outstanding feature with discoverability challenges.	Better communicate AI-powered workspace creation using examples, tutorials, or guided prompts.	★★★★★
Sidebar Navigation	Explore and navigate the workspace.	😊 Comfortable	The sidebar is clean, logically organized, and easy to navigate. Advanced features such as Agents could benefit from contextual guidance for first-time users.	Excellent navigation with minor opportunities for feature discovery.	Introduce contextual tooltips or guided walkthroughs for advanced features.	★★★★☆

Journey Overview

The onboarding journey provides a smooth and engaging introduction to Notion, balancing simplicity with powerful functionality. The strongest moments occur when users experience AI-powered workspace generation, which quickly demonstrates the product's value. Most onboarding friction stems not from missing functionality but from communication, information hierarchy, and feature discoverability. Small improvements in messaging, contextual guidance, and onboarding flow could significantly improve activation and first-time user confidence without requiring major product redesign.

▼ Key Journey Insights

● Strengths

- Clean and intuitive onboarding experience.
- Fast and frictionless account creation.
- AI-powered workspace generation creates a strong early value demonstration.
- Well-structured navigation that supports long-term usability.

● Improvement Opportunities

- Clarify CTA messaging for new users.
- Reduce friction during workspace creation.
- Improve discoverability of AI capabilities.
- Increase transparency around desktop permissions.
- Provide contextual guidance for advanced features.

5. Observations

Stage	Screen Goal	Positive Observation	Opportunity for Improvement	Severity	Business Impact	Recommendation	Effort
Landing Page	Introduce Notion and encourage visitors to create an account.	The landing page has a clean design, a clear value proposition, and a prominent primary CTA that quickly draws attention.	The primary CTA " Get Notion Free " does not clearly communicate what happens after clicking. Additionally, both " Get Notion Free " and " Log in " initially lead to the same account entry flow, making the distinction between new and existing users less obvious.	● Medium	New visitors may hesitate or question whether they selected the correct option, creating unnecessary friction during the very first interaction.	Add supporting microcopy such as " Create your free workspace – No credit card required. " Differentiate the login flow by immediately emphasizing sign-in for existing users.	● Low
Signup	Enable users to create an account quickly and with minimal friction.	The Google sign-up option makes account creation fast and effortless. The process requires very little user input, reducing signup friction.	The sign-up flow is smooth, but users are not informed about what the onboarding process will include after account creation. Setting expectations earlier could reduce uncertainty.	● Low	Users generally prefer knowing how many steps remain before accessing the product. Small improvements in transparency can improve perceived onboarding speed.	Show a short onboarding overview such as " Only 3 quick steps to personalize your workspace. "	● Low
Email Verification	Verify user identity and secure the	Email verification is straightforward	After verification, users are	● Low	A confirmation message provides	Display a success message such as	● Low

Stage	Screen Goal	Positive Observation	Opportunity for Improvement	Severity	Business Impact	Recommendation	Effort
	account before onboarding begins.	and completes quickly without unnecessary complexity. Instructions are clear and easy to follow.	redirected immediately into onboarding without a brief confirmation that verification was successful or what happens next.		reassurance and helps users understand that the process is progressing as expected.	"Email verified successfully! Let's set up your workspace." before continuing.	
Join Teammates or create a workspace	Allow users to join existing workspaces or create a new one.	Displaying existing workspace invitations immediately is valuable for users who signed up through a team invitation.	As a first-time user, I was shown approximately 50 workspace invitations , requiring significant scrolling before reaching the "Create new workspace" button. The interface prioritizes joining existing workspaces over the primary onboarding goal of creating a personal workspace.	● High	New users may become confused about why they already have numerous invitations, increasing cognitive load and delaying their first successful interaction with the product.	Adapt the onboarding based on user intent. If the user signs up independently, prioritize "Create your workspace" while grouping invitations into a separate expandable section or displaying them after workspace creation.	● Medium
How do you want to use Notion?	Personalize the onboarding experience based on the user's intended use case.	The page clearly explains why this information is collected. The three options (Work, Personal, School) are simple, visually distinct, and easy to understand.	The "Improve AI for your workspace" option is placed below the primary onboarding flow and after the Continue button. Its placement and visual hierarchy make it easy to overlook, even though AI is one of Notion's most valuable features. The wording focuses on improving AI rather than explaining the user benefit.	● Medium	Lower visibility may reduce AI participation and awareness of one of Notion's strongest differentiating features, limiting early engagement with AI-powered capabilities.	Increase visibility by repositioning the AI option closer to the primary flow and use benefit-oriented wording such as "Enable smarter AI suggestions for your workspace." Add a small icon or visual highlight to draw attention.	● Low

Stage	Screen Goal	Positive Observation	Opportunity for Improvement	Severity	Business Impact	Recommendation	Effort
Get the Desktop App	Encourage users to install the desktop application by highlighting its benefits.	The page clearly communicates performance improvements and productivity benefits while allowing users to skip installation without blocking onboarding.	The page promotes speed and exclusive features but does not clearly communicate other practical benefits (where applicable, such as improved offline usability). Additionally, users may have privacy concerns when the desktop application later requests access to local files and other apps without prior explanation.	● Medium	Lack of transparency around permissions may reduce user trust or cause hesitation during installation, especially for users unfamiliar with productivity applications.	Before requesting permissions, explain why they are needed (e.g., attaching local files, importing content, syncing data). If applicable, highlight additional user-focused benefits such as offline productivity.	● Medium
AI Welcome / Workspace Generation	Help users begin using Notion by leveraging AI to create a personalized workspace based on their goals.	The AI onboarding experience is highly personalized and significantly reduces the effort required to build a workspace from scratch. Once users describe their needs, Notion automatically generates a structured workspace, creating a strong "wow moment" and demonstrating the practical value of AI.	The welcome screen does not clearly communicate that users can simply describe what they need and Notion AI will build the entire workspace automatically. First-time users may perceive the page as a standard AI chat interface rather than a workspace generation tool. Additionally, there is no short tutorial or example prompt to help users understand what is possible.	● Medium	If users fail to recognize this capability, they may skip one of Notion's strongest differentiating features, reducing early product activation, AI adoption, and the likelihood of experiencing an immediate "aha!" moment.	Improve feature discoverability by adding onboarding guidance such as "Describe your workflow and Notion AI will build your workspace in seconds." Include 2–3 example prompts, a short animated demonstration, or a guided first interaction to help users understand the feature before they begin typing.	● Low
Sidebar / Navigation	Provide users with quick	The sidebar presents a	While the sidebar is	● Low	Minor uncertainty	Introduce contextual	● Low

Stage	Screen Goal	Positive Observation	Opportunity for Improvement	Severity	Business Impact	Recommendation	Effort
	access to their workspace, important pages, navigation tools, and workspace progress.	clean and well-organized navigation structure. Primary navigation (Home, Inbox, Search), workspace setup progress, AI agents, user pages, and utility options (Library, Help, Trash) are grouped logically, making it easy for users to understand the workspace hierarchy. The onboarding progress bar also gives users a sense of progression and encourages completion of setup.	intuitive overall, first-time users may not immediately understand the purpose of sections such as Agents or the distinction between Home and user-created pages. The interface relies on exploration rather than explanation for these newer features.		during the first session may reduce discovery of advanced features like AI Agents, although it is unlikely to prevent users from completing core onboarding.	tooltips or a short guided walkthrough for new users that briefly explains major sidebar sections (e.g., Home, Agents, Workspace Pages, Library). This would improve feature discoverability without adding visual clutter.	

6. Key Insights

Introduction

The customer journey analysis identified several recurring patterns that influence first-time user activation, feature adoption, and overall onboarding experience. While Notion delivers a highly polished onboarding journey, the analysis reveals opportunities to improve clarity, discoverability, and user confidence through relatively small product enhancements.



The onboarding experience is smooth, but clarity can be improved at key decision points.

Finding

Most onboarding screens are intuitive and easy to complete. However, moments such as account creation, workspace setup, and AI configuration present small communication gaps that may cause hesitation for first-time users.

Business Impact

Improving communication at these touchpoints can reduce uncertainty and help users progress through onboarding with greater confidence.

Evidence from Analysis

- **Landing Page:** CTA wording and login flow create uncertainty.
- **Email Verification:** No success confirmation message.
- **Personalization:** AI option lacks visibility.
- **Desktop App:** Permission requests lack context.



The highest onboarding friction occurs before users experience the product's value.

Finding

The workspace creation stage introduces the greatest cognitive load due to the prominence of workspace invitations. This delays users from creating their own workspace and reaching their first meaningful interaction with the product.

Business Impact

Reducing friction before activation can help users reach their "Time to First Value" more quickly, increasing the likelihood of continued engagement.

Supporting Evidence

- **Workspace Creation:** Invitation list delays workspace creation.
- **Journey Rating:** Lowest-rated onboarding stage (★☆☆☆☆).
- **Activation:** Highest observed friction before first value.



AI Delivers the Strongest "Aha!" Moment, but Its Value Is Not Clearly Communicated Upfront

Finding

Notion AI demonstrates significant value by generating complete workspaces from simple prompts. However, this capability is not communicated clearly before users begin interacting with it.

Business Impact

Improving AI discoverability could increase feature adoption while reinforcing Notion's value proposition early in the customer journey.

Supporting Evidence

- **AI Workspace:** Creates complete workspaces instantly.
- **Personalization:** AI participation receives low visibility.
- **Feature Discovery:** Limited guidance before AI interaction.



Most improvement opportunities involve communication rather than functionality.

Finding

The analysis found very few missing features. Instead, most opportunities relate to messaging, information hierarchy, contextual guidance, and onboarding communication.

Business Impact

These improvements can enhance the user experience without requiring major product development, making them relatively low-effort, high-impact opportunities.

Supporting Evidence

- **Landing Page:** CTA messaging refinement.
- **Email Verification:** Confirmation messaging.
- **Desktop App:** Permission transparency.
- **Sidebar:** Contextual guidance over redesign.



Contextual guidance can improve feature discoverability.

Finding

Advanced features such as AI options, Agents, and desktop permissions rely on users discovering them independently. Additional contextual guidance could help users better understand and adopt these capabilities.

Business Impact

Improved feature discoverability can increase product adoption and encourage users to explore more of Notion's functionality.

Supporting Evidence

- **Personalization:** AI option easily overlooked.
- **AI Workspace:** No example prompts or walkthrough.
- **Sidebar:** Advanced features introduced without guidance.



Notion establishes a strong foundation for long-term user engagement.

Finding

Despite a few onboarding friction points, the overall experience is intuitive, visually consistent, and progressively introduces users to increasingly powerful capabilities.

Business Impact

A strong onboarding foundation supports higher user satisfaction and creates favorable conditions for long-term product adoption and retention.

Supporting Evidence

- **Landing Page:** Clear value proposition.
- **Sign-up:** Fast and frictionless experience.
- **Journey Ratings:** Most stages rated 4–5 stars.
- **Overall Journey:** Intuitive and consistent onboarding.

7. Pain Points

Introduction

The analysis identified several recurring pain points that may affect first-time user confidence, product activation, and feature adoption. While Notion provides a strong overall onboarding experience, addressing the following issues could further improve customer satisfaction and long-term engagement.



Onboarding Friction During Workspace Creation

Description

Workspace invitations are prioritized over personal workspace creation, increasing cognitive load and delaying users from reaching their first meaningful product experience.

Business Impact

- Delays activation
- Increases onboarding friction
- May reduce first-time user confidence

Affected Stage(s)

- Workspace Creation

Priority

● High



Lack of Contextual Communication

Description

Several onboarding screens provide limited contextual information, leaving users uncertain about what will happen next or why certain actions are required.

Business Impact

- Creates uncertainty
- Reduces user confidence
- Interrupts onboarding flow

Affected Stage(s)

- Landing Page
- Email Verification
- Desktop App Recommendation

Priority

● Medium



Limited Feature Discoverability

Description

High-value capabilities such as AI workspace generation and advanced navigation features are not sufficiently highlighted, making them easy for new users to overlook.

Business Impact

- Lower feature adoption
- Reduced product exploration
- Missed opportunities to demonstrate value

Affected Stage(s)

- Personalization
- AI Workspace Generation
- Sidebar Navigation

Priority

● Medium



Cognitive Load at Key Decision Points

Description

Some onboarding screens present multiple choices or information without sufficient guidance, increasing the mental effort required from first-time users.

Business Impact

- Slower decision-making
- Higher onboarding effort
- Potential drop in engagement

Affected Stage(s)

- Workspace Creation
- Personalization

Priority

● Medium



Limited Transparency During Permission Requests

Description

Permission requests for the desktop application are presented without clearly explaining why access is needed or how it benefits the user.

Business Impact

- Lower trust
- Increased hesitation
- Reduced installation rate

Affected Stage(s)

- Desktop App Recommendation

Priority

● Low

8. Improvement Opportunities

Introduction

Based on the identified pain points and customer journey analysis, the following recommendations are prioritized by expected business impact and implementation effort. This roadmap highlights opportunities that can improve activation, feature adoption, and the overall onboarding experience.

● Quick Wins

High Impact • Low Effort

Recommendation	Business Benefit	Priority
Clarify landing page CTA	Reduces user uncertainty	●
Add email verification confirmation	Improves user confidence	●
Explain desktop permissions	Builds trust	●
Improve AI option visibility	Increases feature adoption	●

● Medium-Term Improvements

High Impact • Medium Effort

Recommendation	Business Benefit	Priority
Simplify workspace creation	Faster activation	●
Add contextual onboarding tips	Reduces confusion	●
Show AI workspace examples	Encourages exploration	●

● Strategic Enhancements

Long-Term Investment

Recommendation	Business Benefit	Priority
Personalized onboarding	Better user engagement	●
Progressive feature education	Improves retention	●
Behavior-based onboarding guidance	Higher long-term adoption	●



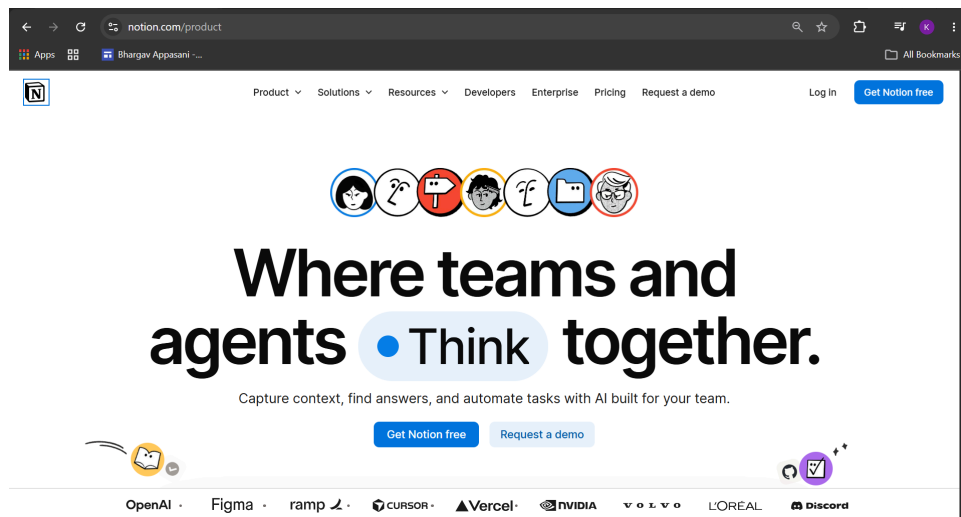
Expected Outcomes

Implementing these recommendations can:

- 🚀 Reduce onboarding friction
- 😊 Improve first-time user confidence
- 🧠 Increase AI and feature adoption
- 📈 Accelerate product activation
- ❤️ Strengthen long-term user engagement

9. Screenshots

Figure 1. Landing Page



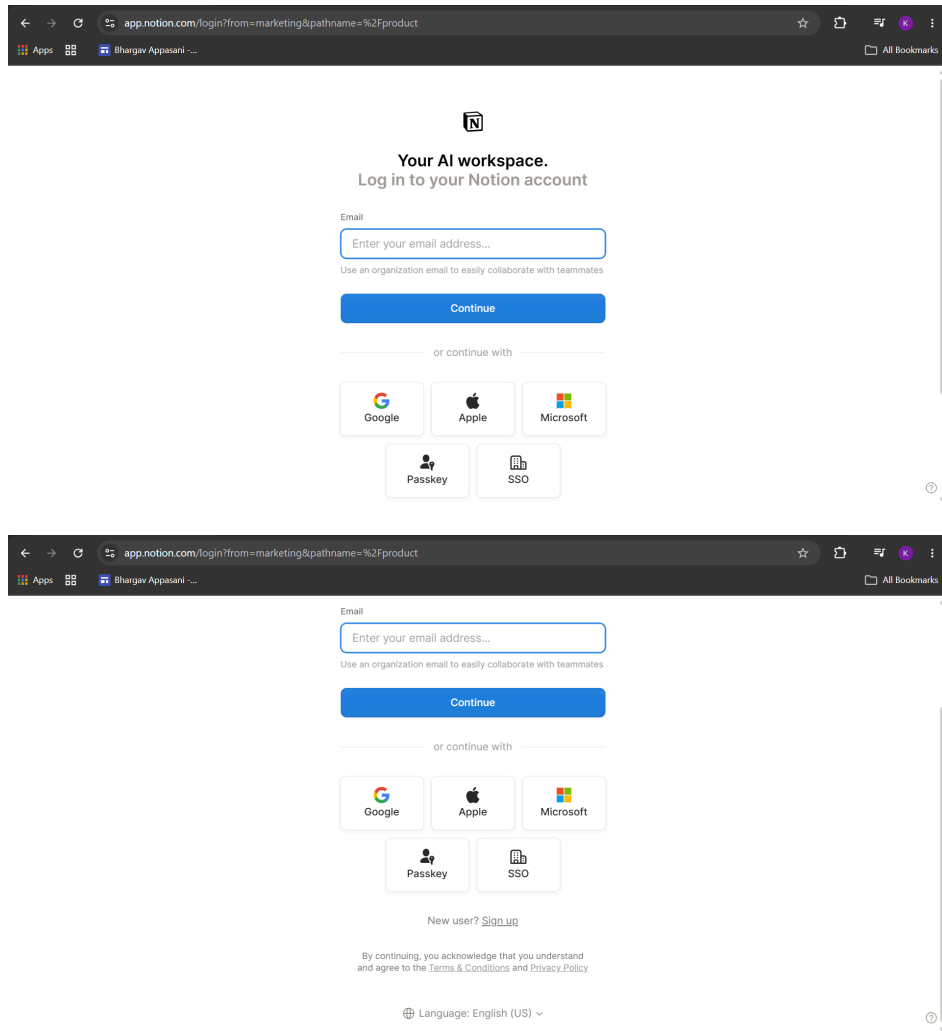
Description

Shows Notion's landing page, including the primary value proposition and call-to-action presented to first-time visitors.

Related Analysis

- Observation 1
- Key Insight 1
- Pain Point 2

Figure 2. Sign-up



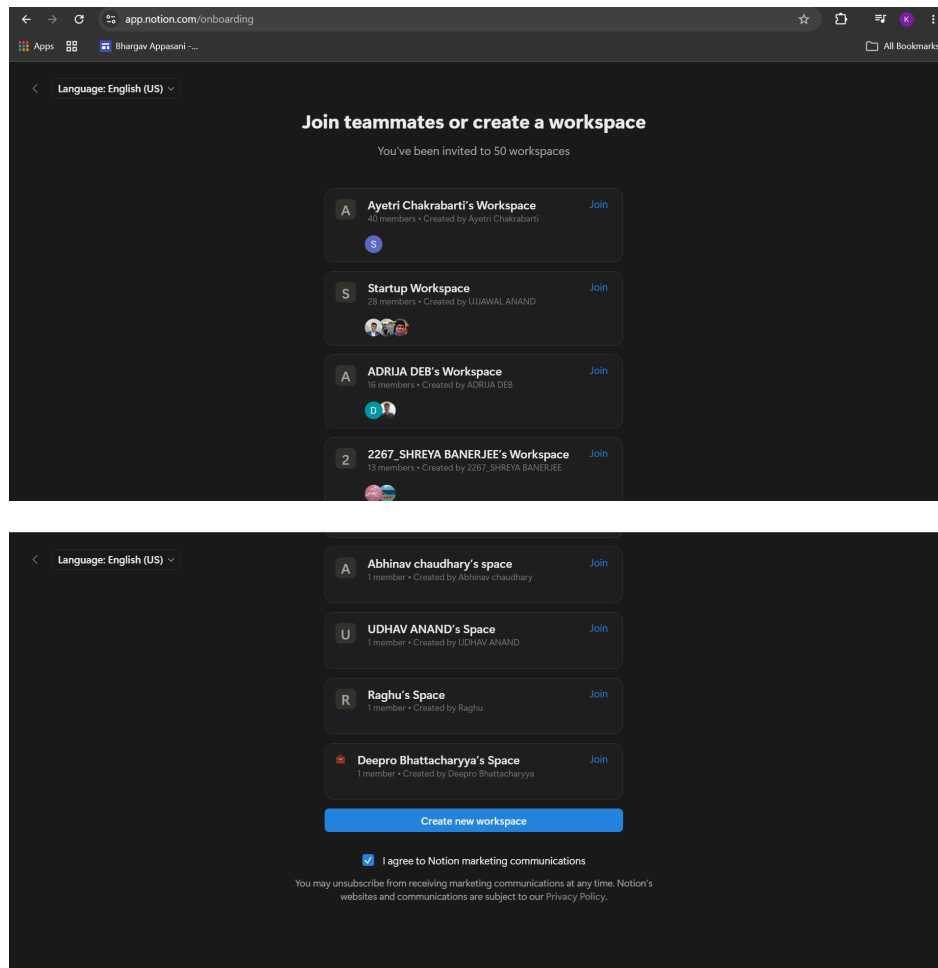
Description

Illustrates the account creation process for new users.

Related Analysis

- Observation 2
- Success Criteria

Figure 3. Workspace Creation



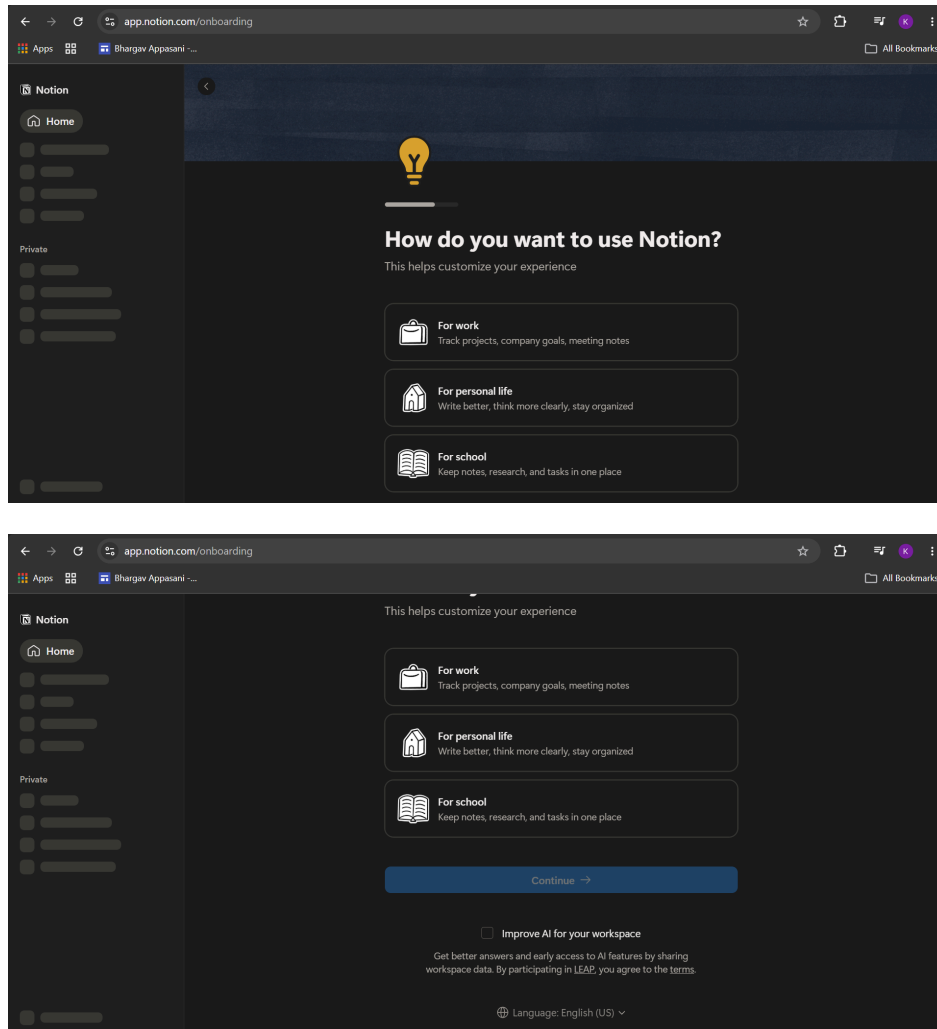
Description

Shows the workspace creation interface where invitation options compete with the primary onboarding task.

Related Analysis

- Observation 4
- Insight 2
- Pain Point 1

Figure 4. Personalization



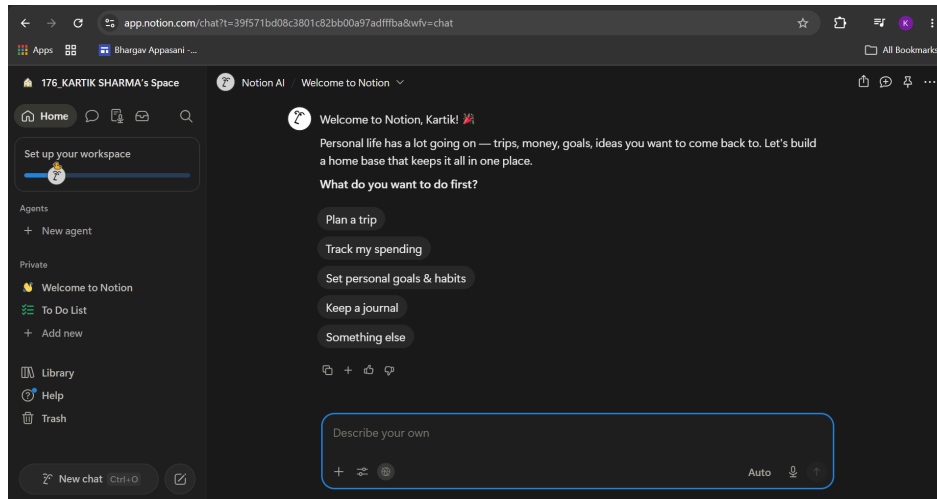
Description

Illustrates the onboarding personalization screen where users select their intended use cases.

Related Analysis

- Observation 5
- Insight 3
- Pain Point 3

Figure 5. AI Workspace Generation



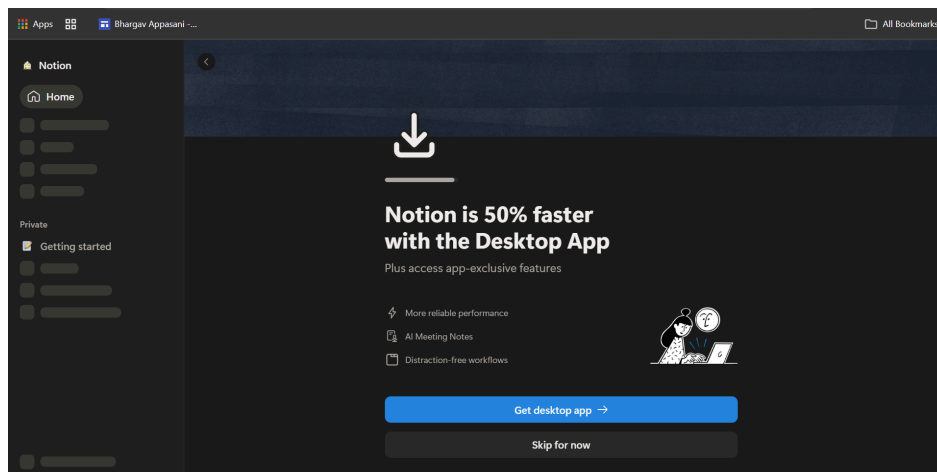
Description

Shows Notion AI automatically generating a workspace based on user inputs.

Related Analysis

- Observation 6
- Insight 3

Figure 6. Desktop App Recommendation



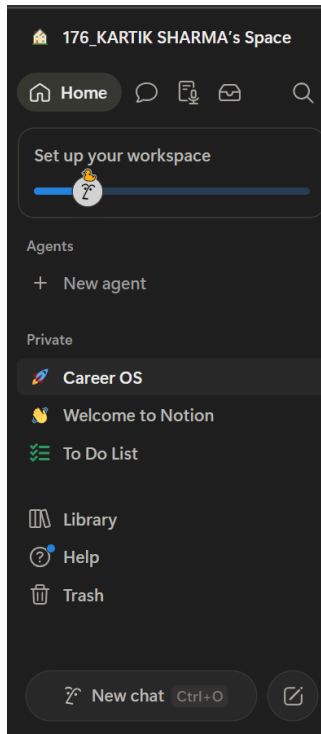
Description

Displays the desktop application installation prompt and permission request.

Related Analysis

- Observation 7
- Pain Point 5

Figure 7. Sidebar Navigation



Description

Shows the main workspace interface used to evaluate feature discoverability and navigation.

Related Analysis

- Observation 8
- Insight 5

10. Conclusion

This analysis demonstrates that Notion already provides a strong onboarding experience, with intuitive navigation, fast account creation, and innovative AI capabilities. Most improvement opportunities relate to communication, guidance, and feature discoverability rather than major product redesigns. Addressing these areas can reduce onboarding friction, accelerate activation, and strengthen long-term customer engagement while preserving Notion's existing user experience.

11. Disclaimer

This case study is an independent portfolio project created for educational and professional development purposes. It is not affiliated with, endorsed by, or commissioned by Notion. All observations, insights, and recommendations are based on the publicly available onboarding experience and the author's firsthand evaluation conducted during July 2026.

12. References

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- Industry best practices in Customer Success, User Experience (UX), and Customer Journey Mapping.
- Personal observations and firsthand evaluation conducted during the end-to-end onboarding journey of Notion (July 2026).

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Customer Success | Business Analysis | Customer Experience

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